

Treatment Tips

OPTIONS FOR ENDING A SESSION

Some people close their eyes for much or all of a session and are likely to lose track of time; others do not. Some people like a 5-minute warning; others may prefer a longer lead-time. Depending on a client's preference, you can say something like this to wrap up a session:

- “We have just a few minutes left today....”
- “We are almost out of time....”
- “We’ll need to finish soon....”

Then, depending on what's happening, offer some options:

- If you are negotiating with a protector:
 - “We have to stop in a couple of minutes, would this part like us to come back next week and pay attention?”
- If the answer is no:
 - “Okay. Would it be okay to return next week just to keep talking about this?”
- If witnessing an exile:
 - “Where would this part like to be between now and our next session that would feel safe and comfortable?”

BETWEEN SESSIONS FOR CLIENTS

If you are in dialogue with a part, you will want to set an intention to return.

- “Where would this part like to be in the meantime? It doesn't have to move, but if it would like to stay somewhere else it can be in any time or any place. Ask it to show you where it would like to be and what it will need there during the week.”
- “If the part would like this, would you be available to check in?”

- If yes:
 - “If you say you’ll do this, be sure to follow through. Is there a time of day that you could check in regularly, like when you wake up or go to bed?”

Sometimes parts just want to be able to call on the client if needed, in which case ask:

- “How would this part like to get your attention if it wants you? And what will you say to it if you can’t pay attention in that exact moment?”
- If the client says “I don’t know” offer options:
 - “You could say ‘I’m busy right now but I will get back to you at 4 pm when I’m done with these phone calls,’ or whatever the situation requires. But if you set that intention, write yourself a note so that you do it. To be trusted, be consistent.”

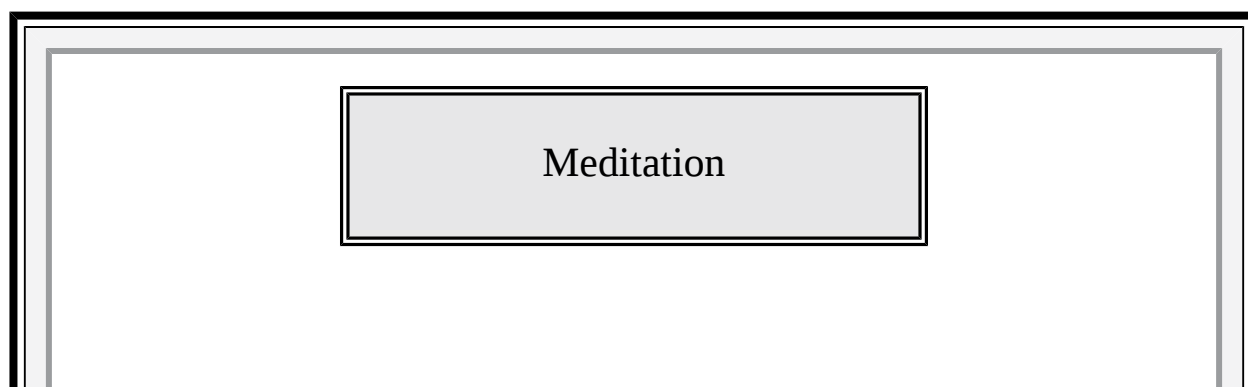
After closing with the target part, check with the system as a whole.

- “Does any part want you to know anything or want anything from you before we stop today?”
- “Does anyone want anything from you during the coming week?”
- “Okay, let’s have all your parts go back inside and take back their energy so you can function in your life between now and our next session.”

BETWEEN SESSIONS FOR THERAPISTS

It is a good practice for therapist’s to take a few minutes in between sessions to check-in with their parts. Parts can get activated by the previous client and need some attention, or other parts might be nervous and apprehensive about the upcoming client.

You can make a regular practice of using the following meditation between sessions to clear the energy of your activated parts so that you are open and available with your next client.



THERAPIST CHECK-IN BETWEEN SESSIONS

- Close your eyes (if that feels comfortable) and ask inside if your previous client triggered any of your parts.
- Ask your parts if they need anything from you now. See if they are willing to relax.
 - If not, set an intention with them to follow-up at a later time – and be specific about when you will check back with them – and then ask them to go into a waiting room (in your mind) while you see your next client.
- Make room inside to bring Self-energy to the experience of being triggered by your last client.
- When those parts step back, notice the internal space that is created.
- Now ask if your parts feel apprehensive about your next client.
 - Listen to their concerns and let them know that they can rest near you during the session or, if it would feel more comfortable, they can go into a waiting room.
 - Ask if they can trust your Self to handle the next session.
- Again, connect with your Self before you proceed with your next client.

TROUBLE-SHOOTING: COMMON OBSTACLES AND FAQ'S

- The client doesn't like the IFS language and is puzzled by the idea of parts.
 - Knowing the client is talking about a part, stay with the client's language. "So when you get angry," or "When you eat too much."
- The client is uncomfortable paying attention to internal experiencing: sensations, feelings or thoughts.

- Ask for permission to find out why and then listen to the reasons. Often the problem is exile overwhelm or fear of giving an extreme protector too much power.
- The client believes parts are evidence of pathology.
 - We normalize psychic multiplicity and validate the positive intention of parts.
- The client is compliant but not engaged.
 - Make this observation in a friendly way and ask if it's okay to be curious about it. Then find the part (usually a Self-like part) who is taking the client out and ask about its motive.
- The client's parts present in a confusing whirl.
 - Be patient, observe that this is the case, inquire why such a presentation might be important.
- The client just wants to tell stories and ask your opinion.
 - Appreciate this protector and ask if it is willing to be direct about its concerns instead of blocking other parts from having a chance to be heard.
- The client is blended with a difficult or scary part:
- An exile with intense negative feelings that threaten to overwhelm.
 - A cruel critic.
 - A self-harming or suicidal part.
 - An enraged part.
 - Use direct access to talk to the part.
- The client's protectors won't make room for the Self.
 - Trust your Self to take the lead and explore.
 - There may be an activated Self-like part.
 - A protective part may have negative feelings toward the client's Self.